Oxford summative assessment formats

All 40 formats with proportionate direct-evidence design strategies

PURPOSE

Use this reference when selecting or strengthening an Oxford summative assessment format. The strategies focus on making the intended knowledge, reasoning, judgement, process or performance visible. No format, process record or oral component automatically proves authorship or eliminates unauthorised assistance. Where AI could materially obscure the capability being assessed, use more than one proportionate source of evidence and ensure any additional component is specified in advance, accessible, consistently applied and locally approved.

FORMAT	TYPE	TASK	DESCRIPTION	PROPORTIONATE DIRECT-EVIDENCE DESIGN STRATEGIES
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	**Essays**	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when effectively and accessibly implemented. Use questions that require synthesis, application and justified critical positioning. Refresh question banks for assessment quality and security, not because novelty makes a question inaccessible to AI. Follow Oxford Examination Regulations.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	**Multiple choice questions**	Students are required to select the correct answer from a list of possible answers.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when effectively and accessibly implemented. Design application-, analysis- and evaluation-level items, including scenarios or case vignettes. Refresh item banks for quality and security; variation does not by itself establish authorship.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	**Short-answer questions**	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer or annotate a diagram.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when effectively and accessibly implemented. Use supplied diagrams, data or primary sources and ask for annotation, justification or application. Vary parameters for breadth and assessment quality, not as proof against AI use.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	**Problem / computational question**	Students present written solutions to problems, explaining their rationale for the approach(es) taken.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when effectively and accessibly implemented. Ask students to show workings, justify method choices and explain why an approach is appropriate. Vary parameters and scenarios for breadth and quality, not as a guarantee against assistance.
Written Exam	In-person, timed invigilated	**Unseen translation**	A writing task that assesses competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Controlled, device-restricted and invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of independent performance when effectively and accessibly implemented. Choose passages appropriate to the intended linguistic capability and ask for a translator's commentary on stylistic and linguistic choices. Do not rely on restricted or unpublished status as a safeguard by itself.

FORMAT	TYPE	TASK	DESCRIPTION	PROPORTIONATE DIRECT-EVIDENCE DESIGN STRATEGIES
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	**Essays**	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate platform controls and contingency arrangements; do not assume they eliminate access to other devices or services. Declare AI permissions clearly in advance. Teaching-unit-specific prompts, question-bank rotation and randomisation can support assessment quality but do not prove independent authorship.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	**Multiple choice questions**	Students are required to select the correct answer from a list of possible answers.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate platform controls and clear contingency arrangements; do not assume they eliminate unauthorised assistance. Randomise item order where suitable and design application-level, scenario-based questions. Declare and implement the AI permission clearly in advance.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	**Short-answer questions**	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer or annotate a diagram.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate platform controls and contingency arrangements. Draw questions from a balanced bank, use supplied data or sources and ask students to justify responses. Declare the AI permission clearly; platform settings reduce opportunity but do not establish authorship by themselves.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	**Problem / computation questions**	Students present written solutions to problems, explaining their rationale for the approach(es) taken.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate platform controls and contingency arrangements. Vary numerical parameters where pedagogically suitable and ask for method justification alongside calculations. Declare the AI permission clearly; controls and variation do not by themselves prove independent performance.
Written Exam	Online, timed, invigilated	**Unseen translation**	A writing task that assesses competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Where online invigilation is approved and accessible, use appropriate platform controls and contingency arrangements. Choose passages appropriate to the intended capability and ask for commentary on linguistic and stylistic choices. Declare the AI permission clearly. Do not rely on a passage being absent from public corpora as a safeguard by itself.
Written Exam	Online, open book, timed (up to 3 hours)	**Essays**	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	Open-book conditions may make AI accessible. Declare AI permissions clearly in advance. Design prompts that require synthesis of named course sources, application to supplied material and a justified critical position. These strategies strengthen evidence of judgement but do not make the assessment AI-proof or enforce a prohibition on their own.
Written Exam	Online, open book, timed (up to 3 hours)	**Short-answer questions**	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer or annotate a diagram.	Use supplied passages, data or sources and ask students to annotate, interpret or apply relevant frameworks. Require concise justification where reasoning is part of the intended learning. Declare AI permissions clearly in advance. Course-specific or recent material supports relevance but does not by itself verify authorship.

FORMAT	TYPE	TASK	DESCRIPTION	PROPORTIONATE DIRECT-EVIDENCE DESIGN STRATEGIES
Written Exam	Online, open book, timed (up to 3 hours)	**Case study response**	Students respond to a real-world problem or challenge; this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Ground the case in specific supplied evidence and a defined decision context. Require a prioritised response, explicit reasoning, assumptions and trade-offs. Declare AI permissions clearly in advance. Local or novel scenarios can improve authenticity but should not be treated as proof that AI assistance was unavailable.
Written Exam	Online, open book, window (2 or 3 day)	**Essays**	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	An extended window can weaken the inference that the submission alone evidences the student's capability. Declare AI permissions before the window opens. Strengthen the task through direct engagement with supplied evidence and use proportionate process evidence only where it contributes to validity. An oral follow-up should be planned, accessible, consistently applied and locally approved; no component proves authorship.
Written Exam	Online, open book, window (2 or 3 day)	**Short-answer questions**	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence, provide a short descriptive answer or annotate a diagram.	Use coherent multi-part questions that require a consistent thread of reasoning, direct engagement with supplied material and explicit justification. Declare AI permissions clearly in advance. Teaching-unit-specific or unpublished material may support relevance but should not be treated as proof of independent authorship.
Written Exam	Online, open book, window (2 or 3 day)	**Case study response**	Students respond to a real-world problem or challenge; this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Use a defined decision context and specific supplied evidence. Ask students to identify assumptions, limitations and trade-offs or to evaluate AI-generated analysis where this aligns with the learning outcome. Declare AI permissions clearly. Localisation or novelty should not be relied upon as the principal safeguard.
Written Exam	Online, open book, long duration (1, 2 or 3 days)	**Essays**	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject.	A long assessment window can weaken the inference that the submission alone evidences the student's capability. Declare AI permissions clearly. Consider a process commentary, annotated plan or other evidence only where it supports learning, is manageable and is specified in advance. Any oral component should be proportionate, accessible, consistently applied and locally approved.
Written Exam	Online, open book, long duration (1, 2 or 3 days)	**Case study response**	Students respond to a real-world problem or challenge; this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Where primary data collection, fieldwork or local evidence is part of the intended learning, require students to interpret that evidence directly. Make assumptions, limitations and decision-making visible and declare AI permissions clearly. A reflective process section can add context but does not by itself prove authorship.

FORMAT	TYPE	TASK	DESCRIPTION	PROPORTIONATE DIRECT-EVIDENCE DESIGN STRATEGIES
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	**Take-away or take-home essays**	Essays written after teaching has been completed and in response to a list of questions or titles released at a scheduled time. Students typically have around a week to select title(s) and complete their work.	Declare AI permissions clearly before the assessment window opens. Strengthen the task through engagement with supplied or course-specific evidence, a justified critical position and marking criteria that reward reasoning. Use annotated source notes, plans or process evidence only where proportionate. A brief oral follow-up is one possible form of triangulation if planned, accessible, consistently applied and locally approved.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	**Case studies**	Students find, select and argue for solutions to a real-world problem or challenge and either write up or orally present their findings.	Use a specific case, decision context and supplied evidence. Ask for a prioritised recommendation, explicit reasoning, assumptions and trade-offs. Process documentation or an oral presentation may add evidence where it supports the intended learning and is proportionate, accessible and approved. Declare any permitted AI use and the required declaration.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	**Practical reports**	Concise documents used to communicate the outcomes of an experiment or small-scale project.	Tie the report to the relevant experimental or practical evidence and ask students to justify methodology, interpretation and limitations. Raw data, notebooks or supervisor records can provide context but are not proof of authorship. Declare permitted AI use for analysis, visualisation or writing support and specify how outputs must be checked.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	**Poster assessments**	A form of visual communication which requires students to concisely summarise and prioritise information and/or ideas.	Clarify whether the poster assesses content, visual communication, oral response or all three. Use a live question-and-answer element only where oral explanation is part of the intended learning and it can be consistently and accessibly implemented. Include original or supplied evidence where relevant and use reflective process evidence proportionately. Declare AI permissions.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	**Business plans and design proposals**	Documents which set out to persuade potential funders of the feasibility and profitability of a new product or service and how this will be achieved.	Use a defined client brief, evidence base and decision context. Assess feasibility, trade-offs and justification rather than polish alone. An oral pitch, process documentation or client interaction may provide additional evidence where aligned, accessible and approved. Do not rely on the scenario being unfamiliar to AI. Declare permitted AI use and verification responsibilities.
Submission	Short duration (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	**Translations**	Assess competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Choose source texts appropriate to the intended translation capability and ask for commentary explaining linguistic and stylistic choices. Declare AI permissions clearly in advance. Restricted, unpublished or recently published status may support assessment quality but should not be treated as proof that AI assistance was unavailable.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Dissertation / Thesis**	Extensive pieces of work based on supervised independent research or investigation. The title and focus are often developed by the student. Often completed at the culmination of the degree programme.	Declare AI permissions for the specific work and stage. Use supervision and milestones as developmental evidence, not forensic proof. Require primary sources, original data or fieldwork where these are part of the intended research capability. A well-designed viva can provide strong evidence of understanding, but it is not a universal requirement or proof of authorship. Require the locally prescribed declaration.

FORMAT	TYPE	TASK	DESCRIPTION	PROPORTIONATE DIRECT-EVIDENCE DESIGN STRATEGIES
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Extended essays**	A longer essay written on a topic of the student's choice. Can be written in response to pre-set questions or on a title the student has developed. Students usually receive limited supervision and may be entitled to feedback on draft work.	Align the title and task with the student's intended research and disciplinary context. Use research notes, annotated sources or drafts only where they support development and assessment validity. Declare AI permissions clearly. A brief oral follow-up may provide additional evidence if planned, accessible, consistently applied and locally approved.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Mini-projects and structured projects**	Students are challenged to address more open-ended questions, extend a known result or work with an industry partner on a problem. Mini-projects are typically released after teaching is completed; structured projects run over a longer period with supervision.	Use notebooks, code, design records or process logs where they support the intended learning and remain manageable. Regular check-ins and milestone reviews can make development visible but do not prove authorship. Declare AI permissions; where AI tools are permitted, require critical evaluation, testing and an appropriate declaration.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Fieldwork, site, museum and industrial visit reports**	Assess students' learning through fieldwork, a site or museum visit or an industrial visit. Generally presented in a clearly structured format.	Tie the task to the relevant fieldwork, visit or situated experience. Use dated notes, observations, material evidence or reflection where these genuinely evidence the intended learning, while avoiding unnecessary surveillance. Declare AI permissions for the write-up phase and make clear that contemporaneous records provide context rather than proof of authorship.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Portfolio**	A collection of shorter pieces of work chosen by the student to demonstrate their competence and interest in a particular area.	Ask students to explain the selection, development and relationship of portfolio pieces and to reflect on their learning trajectory. Include drafts or iterations where they support the intended learning and are manageable. Mark curation, evidence and judgement rather than assuming personal reflection establishes authorship. Declare AI permissions clearly.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Research papers and articles**	Work follows the format and conventions of a published paper or article in the field, often following the brief of a particular journal.	Where appropriate to the learning outcome, use original data, primary research or a clearly justified argument. Peer review, oral feedback or staged development can provide additional evidence if proportionate and planned. Declare AI permissions for literature work, analysis, visualisation and drafting and require critical evaluation of substantive outputs.
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Business plans and design proposals**	Documents which set out to persuade potential funders of the feasibility and profitability of a new product or service and how this will be achieved.	Use iterative design decisions, mentoring records or a pitch where these support the intended professional capability and can be consistently implemented. Assess evidence, assumptions, trade-offs and feasibility. Declare AI permissions; if AI supports modelling or design, require verification, critical evaluation and an appropriate declaration.

FORMAT	TYPE	TASK	DESCRIPTION	PROPORTIONATE DIRECT-EVIDENCE DESIGN STRATEGIES
Submission	Long duration (typically more than 3 weeks)	**Translations**	Assess competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Choose source texts appropriate to the intended capability and ask for a substantial translator's commentary that makes linguistic judgement visible. Supervision or milestone records can add developmental evidence but do not prove authorship. Declare AI permissions for both translation and commentary phases.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Practical tests and simulations	**Various**	Students are observed conducting a series of defined tasks within a specified period of time and are assessed against a set of pre-determined criteria.	Observed practical performance can provide strong direct evidence of physical, procedural and real-time decision-making capability. Use suitable scenario variation and standardised criteria for assessment quality and fairness. Ensure observation is accessible and consistent, and declare any relevant AI permissions, such as approved AI-assisted diagnostic tools.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Oral presentation	**In relation to a case study, research project or paper**	Assesses knowledge and understanding, as well as the ability to communicate orally and visually. The audience may include peers and members of the department. May be performed live or pre-recorded.	Live delivery and responsive questioning can strengthen evidence of individual understanding and communication. For pre-recorded work, consider a planned live follow-up only where oral response is part of the intended learning and it can be accessible and consistently applied. Declare AI permissions for preparation and require an appropriate declaration for substantive use.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Viva voce and interviews	**In relation to a dissertation or thesis**	Oral examination of a student's understanding of submitted written work and its wider implications. The format may be formal and structured or less formal and dialogic.	A well-designed oral examination can provide strong evidence of individual understanding in real time. Use structured core questions with responsive follow-up to probe reasoning, wider implications and application, while maintaining fairness and accessibility. Declare any AI permissions relating to the submitted work under examination.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Performances, exhibitions and displays	**Musical performance**	Assesses practical application of understanding and knowledge. Allows students to communicate their creative practice to wider audiences.	Live performance can provide strong direct evidence of the assessed practical or artistic capability. Use programme choice, interpretation or improvisation where these align with the learning outcome. For pre-recorded work, consider a planned live commentary or defence only where proportionate and accessible. Declare AI permissions for related composition or arrangement work.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Performances, exhibitions and displays	**Exhibition of created work**	Assessment of original creative work exhibited for an audience.	Use a process portfolio, sketches, drafts or studio notes where they support the intended creative learning. A live commentary or defence may add evidence of the student's choices if planned, accessible and consistently applied; it does not by itself prove authorship. Declare AI permissions and distinguish substantive AI-generated or AI-modified elements where required.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Objective Structured Clinical Examinations (OSCEs)	**Various**	Students undertake a series of tasks in sequence to demonstrate a range of skills and competencies in authentic contexts.	The real-time, multi-station and physical format can provide strong evidence of the assessed clinical capabilities. Use standardised criteria, suitable scenario variation and trained assessors to support validity and fairness. Declare any AI permissions relevant to preparatory simulations or tools used within stations.

FORMAT	TYPE	TASK	DESCRIPTION	PROPORTIONATE DIRECT-EVIDENCE DESIGN STRATEGIES
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Aural examination	**Various**	A series of exercises that assess listening skills, typically in relation to language or musical competency.	Live or closely invigilated conditions can provide strong evidence of listening and spontaneous response. Use varied stimulus material and appropriate spontaneous tasks for assessment quality. Declare and implement the AI permission clearly, including any authorised assistive technology or reasonable adjustments.
Oral, Practical and/or Performed	Oral examination	**Various**	A series of exercises that assess verbal skills, typically in relation to language competency.	Live, controlled oral conditions can provide strong evidence of spontaneous language production. Use varied topics, registers and responsive prompts with consistent criteria. Declare and implement the AI permission clearly. Where pre-recorded elements are used, a planned live follow-up may be appropriate if spontaneity is part of the intended learning and the component is accessible and approved.

IMPLEMENTATION NOTE

Apply current Oxford Examination Regulations, the University policy on AI use in summative assessment, local programme guidance, accessibility requirements, reasonable adjustments and student workload expectations. The format is only one part of validity; alignment, implementation, marking and the evidence students are asked to show are equally important.

Official sources: www.ox.ac.uk/about/how-we-are-run/policies-and-statements/policy-hub/ai-use-in-summative-assessment · www.ox.ac.uk/gen-ai. This guide is practical guidance, not University policy, and has not been formally endorsed.